P01d: 2D Platformer Final Build and Postmortem Rubric

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Section:1

Finished Level Video:

https://youtu.be/50THIhyftgo?si=Ngr2JvbsPcHFD0vw

Design Choices

What type of experience did you want to give the player? How did you plan to achieve that? How did you address the assignment goals?

- I wanted the player to have an experience where they had to stay aware of their surroundings at all times and solve puzzles using their environment.
- I planned to achieve this experience through spatial puzzles, timing challenges, and a need for occasional backtracking
    - I decided that boulder blocks would a good conduit for this; they can be manipulated around space pretty freely, and if placed on bridge blocks could unlock certain paths
    - Laser blocks could be used to create timing challenges. Players must complete **x** objective while avoiding lasers. If they mess up their timing, they must try again
- I addressed the assignment goals by using a variety of battleblock theater mechanics, by following a three act structure with game-beats and traversals, and by focusing on a specific mechanic for the level (boulder maneuverability and light bridges)

Implementation

This is your chance to discuss your process when creating the level. How did you implement your design choices? Were there any changes to your original level sketch that you made as you were making the level?

- When creating the level, I focused on creating four “main” sections
    - Boulder and Bridge Introduction (Time 0:05 - 0:18)
    - Bubblegum Block Drop (Time: 0:31 - 1:05)
    - Conveyor Belt Run (Time 1:20 - 2:04)
    - Enemy Blocking Path (Time 2:09 -2:17)
- These sections ramp up in difficulty, until the final section, which serves as a “cooling-down” point after the climactic conveyor belt run.
- The first three sections involve maneuvering a boulder onto bridge blocks while avoiding lasers. The bubblegum block drop and conveyor belt run involve backtracking and spatial reasoning skills are required.
- While making the level, I changed the feeling of a lot of the jumps and their timing. I also changed the proportions of some sections to make them read better or to make

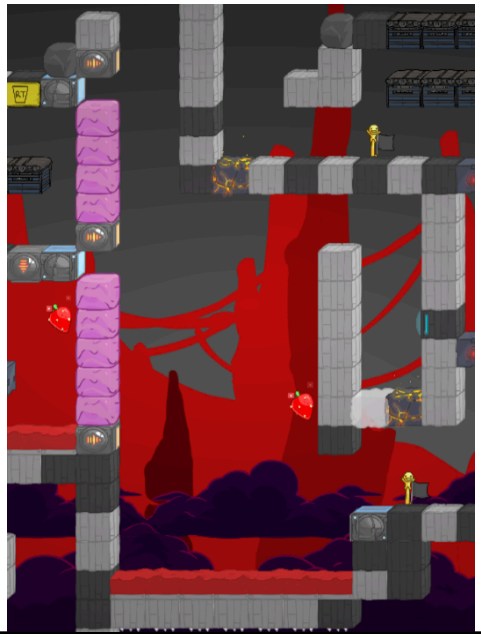
movement flow better.

- I also changed the conveyor belt run section slightly
    - Went from using teleporters to return the boulder to having the boulder fall back to the start with just conveyor belts (the teleporters were messing up the bubblegum drop section, which also used teleporters)
    - Changed the bomb blocks -> trigger blocks. Boulders don't trigger bomb blocks, so trigger blocks were used instead to make the conveyor path have gaps that appear and disappear



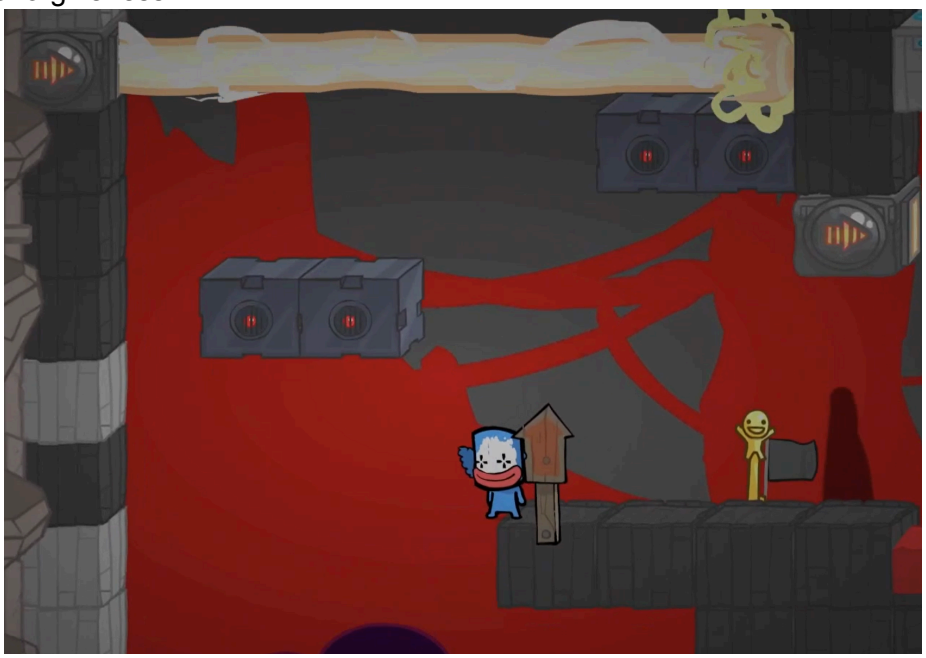
Feedback

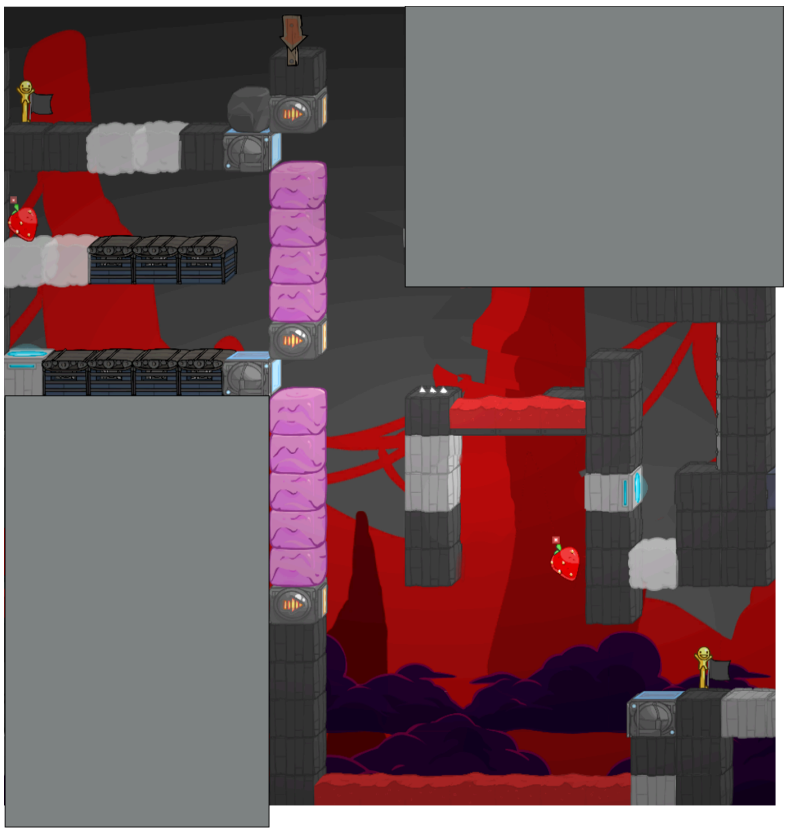
- Overall, players struggled determining what to do with the boulders. They would throw them directly into the water, or back down a previous path, effectively softlocking the level and making it impossible to progress
- Players could also entirely skip the bubblegum drop puzzle with simple parkour
- Conveyor belt puzzle wasn't clear– players didn't know they had to bring the boulder across, and would struggle for a couple of minutes before figuring it out
- Players felt the readability of the level was poor. They couldn't see where lasers were firing and would have to make "leaps of faith" at times.
- However, once they were able to figure out how to complete the puzzles (without softlocking it), they enjoyed the creativity and solutions. They also felt as though the level built upon itself; earlier sections showcasing boulder maneuverability communicated that players would need to maneuver boulders in later sections like the conveyor belt run.
- I learned that players will usually not behave



exactly as expected, and will find ways to break your level that you didn't know was possible
- I disagree with some of the feedback regarding not knowing what to do with the boulders. Two out of the three playtesters that tested my level hadn't played past the first level of BattleBlock Theater. Therefore, they didn't understand some of the core mechanics that my level assumes the player knows (how cloud blocks work, how teleporters work, what bridge blocks were). Once these players discovered how these mechanics worked, they felt the level made more intuitive sense

Further Improvements

- I improved the readability and tightness of jumps in the first climb after the spawn area. Players can now see lasers before they start climbing vertically, so they can time their jumps better and not rely on leaps of faith. Blocks are a little closer together to improve forgiveness
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- I reworked the bubblegum drop section. Players can no longer jump straight to the bottom and skip it. The room with the teleporter and conveyor belts got re-designed to better communicate that players can put boulders through teleporters. It is also designed in such a way that if a player moves the boulder in that room at all, it goes through the teleporter.

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- Boulders are now restricted to the areas in which they must be used. Players can no longer throw boulders into water or into previous sections– removing the ability to softlock the level
  - This was done by surrounding boulder sections with 2-block tall walls. Players are unable to throw the boulder over these walls.
  - Sections displayed below all end up holding boulders
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- Re-designed the traversal area after the conveyor belt run. During playtests, players were unable to backtrack once reaching this area– and if they didn't bring the boulder with them they would softlock themselves
    - Added monkey bars to climb back up
    - Blocked in bridge area to avoid boulder being tossed into water

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